



Figure 2: PAL v2.2.1 wizard (Image credits: Google Images)

thresholds that relate to the majority of the Windows products, including Exchange, Active Directory, Share Point and more. Let's have a look at the various features of PAL:

1. It has an easy-to-use GUI interface that helps in creating batch files for the `PAL.ps1` script.
2. It has a GUI editor, which helps in editing or creating the threshold files.
3. It generates HTML based reports, which makes it easy to copy and paste these to other applications.
4. It analyses different performance counter logs for thresholds that change their criteria on the basis of computer or hardware specifications.
5. It thresholds files for most of the Microsoft products like IIS, SQL Server, Exchange and Active Directory.

The PAL tool is basically developed using *Powershell* script, which requires a different set of arguments or parameters passed to it so that the performance monitor logs can be easily analysed using them.

The system requirements for this tool are:

1. Powershell v2.0 or greater.
2. Microsoft .NET framework 3.5
3. Microsoft Chart Control for Microsoft .NET framework 3.5

Squiggle

Squiggle is similar to a serverless LAN chat tool, which is ready for use the moment it is downloaded, unzipped and run. There is no installation required for it. This tool is ideal for smaller businesses, where Windows sys admins do not have Office 365 with Lync, which could be used for communication. Squiggle even helps to connect two LANs



Figure 3: Squiggle Messenger (Image credits: Google Images)

across different sub-networks or a WAN. Let's check out its other features:

1. It helps in group chat, private chat and broadcast chat.
2. It's basically a serverless peer-to-peer LAN chat, which does not require any installation.
3. It helps in multiple transfers simultaneously, and that too, at high speed.
4. It also has several other features like a spellcheck, emoticons, buzz and audio alerts.
5. It helps to perform voice chat.
6. It can even display pictures, messages, contact groups, chat commands and message aliases.
7. It shows the chat history and status history.
8. With its localisation feature, Windows sys admins can replace the already present translation file with a new one so that Squiggle can be used in some other local language. The system requirements are:

1. NET Framework 4.0
2. Visual C++ 2010 redistributable
3. Windows 8 and above

RamHook

RamHook is an open source, keystroke logging application, which provides sys admins with the ability to capture and record all the keyboard input to a file. This tool is widely used to capture various keyboard inputs. Once these are captured, it generates a log file corresponding to the different keystrokes it has captured, which can be used further for different investigations and other applications. It can even be run in hidden mode, and the log file generated by it can be uploaded to a specified Web server. Its features are listed below:

1. It captures all keyboard inputs.
2. It's highly customisable.
3. It can be run in hidden mode.
4. It's a simple open source tool which is quite straightforward and easy to use.
5. It can upload generated log files to remote servers.
6. It also helps in Windows integration.

Ntop

Ntop is an open source network traffic tool that illustrates network usage in real-time. It is more like the UNIX top command, with which we can view network flow statistics and filter or sort the obtained output data. It helps sys admins to know about the big bandwidth consumers. It produces different network utilisation graphs such as Cacti and MRTG. Windows sys admins prefer Ntop to take NetFlow and Flow data as inputs for analysis. If sys admins need to track down a user who's using more resources than they like, Ntop's operating system sniffing and fingerprinting of user identity information such as email addresses comes in very handy. It supports different management activities such as network optimisation and planning, and helps to detect network security violations. Ntop's features are listed below: